The Noble Black Iron Beak

Āryakṛṣṇāyoṣṭha · Toh 966 · Derge Kangyur
འཕགས་པ་ལྕགས་མཆུ་ནག་པོ།

The Noble Black Iron Beak, known in Sanskrit as Ārya Kṛṣṇāyoṣṭha and in Tibetan as Phakpa Chakchu Nakpo, is a short scripture presented as a discourse of the Buddha, opening with the familiar words "Thus did I hear at one time." It describes the Blessed One staying in a reed thicket at a place where boats come to rest, then setting out with the venerable Ānanda for a place in Jambudvīpa. There, moved by compassion for the beings of that world, he addresses a great assembly of nāga kings, including Anavatapta, Sāgara, Nanda, Takṣaka, and many others, among them kings with many heads, which suggests a text concerned with the powerful serpent spirits associated with water and weather and with protecting beings from harm. It is Toh 966 in the Kangyur, where it belongs among the short ritual and protective works of the kind gathered with the dhāraṇī texts.

In the language of India: ārya kṛṣṇā ya oṣṭha
In the language of Tibet: The Noble Black Iron Beak.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in a reed thicket, at a place where boats rest. Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda, "Ānanda, let us go to that place in Jambudvīpa."

"Venerable One, I shall do so," he replied, and the venerable Ānanda did as the Blessed One said.

Then, out of compassion for the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa, the Blessed One addressed the nāga kings: Anavatapta, Sāgara, Nanda, Takṣaka, Ananta, Śaṅkhapāla, Manasvin, Elāpattra, Lustrous, the nāga king Lightning-Bringer, the nāga king Varuṇa, the nāga king Cloud-Urger, the nine-headed nāga king, the seven-headed nāga king, the five-headed nāga king, and the six-headed, the three-headed, the two-headed and the thousand-headed ones. To them the Blessed One said, "Swear an oath!"

ananaste binanaste biśikiśi agubigu rere hūṃ hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ phaṭ stambhaya bhañjaya basaśarīrani matritra matramani svāhā

By that first set of mantras the nāgas were thrown into turmoil and fainted. "Blessed One, we will not dare to make the crops, the fruits, the medicinal

plants, the trees, the sprouts, the leaves and the flowers wither. We will send down rain in its season. We will make the trees and the forests grow. We will not dare to harm the wealth of the people of Jambudvīpa. We will not harm sentient beings. If we transgress the command of the Blessed One, may the bodies of us nāgas shrivel! May we be left without a dwelling! May our bodies turn rough! May leprosy, scabies and blotched skin break out on us! May our heads split and our hearts burst!" Thus they swore.

Hundreds of thousands of bhūtas with deep faith in the Blessed One also came, for the sake of all sentient beings. "Since they will come to do you great harm, nirgacchata nirgacchata nirgacchata quickly scatter! May those who are hostile toward you be ruined! Those who have loving minds, who wish no harm and wish to protect, let them enter your bodies!"

The Buddha, compassionate toward the world, said:

sumu sumu sumu sumu sumuru sumuru sumuru sumuru sumuru sumuru susu muru muru muru muru muru muru miri miri svāhā

The gods, the nāgas, the asuras, and the male and female yakṣas will swiftly send down streams of rain, as much as is wished. Take the first ninefold portions of water from all the nāga abodes and keep each water separately. Empower them with white mustard seed and cast this into the water. When the mantra is complete, carry the water back to the nāga abodes. Rain will then fall just as one wishes.

"Buddha, compassionate toward the world, you who hold the exceptional intention to benefit sentient beings, who abide in loving-kindness, who possess compassion, who abide in joy, who abide in equanimity, come!"

kṣiprana nirgacchata svāhā nāga yuyu svāhā

Looking at the clouds, face each of the four directions in turn and prostrate; if one recites this fifty times, rain will certainly fall swiftly.

When bringing down rain, go to the abode of a fierce nāga. Wash the body with scented water, eat the three white foods, and give up meat, alcohol, garlic and onions. Cultivating a mind of loving-kindness and facing east, one should supplicate the noble ones.

ribu ribu balayathā hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ svāhā vajra vajra jālaya svāhā sarva duśaṃna biranaśaga svāhā garuḍa hriti svāhā

Stretch a blue canopy over the platform. Set up a blue banner, and an image of a vidyā-mantra holder on a blue seat and in blue garments, its legs, also blue, spread apart. Place blue food offerings, and four vases filled with water at the four corners of the maṇḍala. In the center set out an image of the nāga king Sāgara. On the eastern lotus set the three-headed nāga king. On the southern lotus set the seven-headed nāga king. On the western lotus set the nine-headed nāga king. On the northern lotus set the five-headed nāga. Also set out whatever is given in the texts on ritual activities.

oṃ hi hūṃ phaṭ phaṭ hūṃ bijaya phaṭ phaṭ nāgali jvala śad śad jvali bikrata vajra vajrala mahāpala bīrya parākṛta daraci prameru phaṭ phaṭ du

As soon as this dhāraṇī is spoken, the great earth will quake. Six million koṭis of niyutas of great nāga kings fell on their faces, trembled violently, fainted, rolled about and wept. Then the nāga kings cried out to the Blessed One, saying, "This mantra burns the nāgas terribly. It is ferocious!"

The Blessed One said, "Nāga kings, bring benefit, happiness, good harvests, protection and refuge to the sentient beings of Jambudvīpa, and fill the channels of the fields to the brim. Bring forth abundant crops. Do not harm humans or non-humans. Send down streams of rain. Then you yourselves will have lasting happiness and be free of every affliction that besets the nāgas.

May you many-footed ones be well.
May you four-footed ones be well.
May you two-footed ones be well.
May you footless ones be well.
May you who travel the road be well.
May those who return be well as well.
May you not fall into evil.
As the Buddha goes forth,
Surrounded by thousands of gods,
May those with hostile minds scatter!
May those of compassionate nature come!
Through those who send rain upon this land for its good,
May those who dwell on the earth and in the sky
Be loving toward all creatures."

When there is drought without rain, recite the first set of mantras a hundred times, the middle one fifty times, and the last one seven times. Looking at the clouds, recite the middle one in a whisper, so that no one at all perceives it. If

one exceeds the number, it will turn into hail, and so it is a grave wrong. Since it strikes the nāgas at their vital point, it is a grave wrong. One should not repeat the count again and again. It is impossible that a stream of rain will not fall within one day, two days, or five days.

King of Dharma, free of aging and death,
May the aspirations of all be swiftly fulfilled!

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda and those monks rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the dhāraṇī of the Noble Black Iron Beak.

Translator's Notes

• The command rendered "Swear an oath!" is unclear in the Tibetan; it is read in light of the nāgas' oath that follows. Three nāga king names could not be identified with a Sanskrit form and are translated by meaning: "Lustrous," "Lightning-Bringer," and "Cloud-Urger." The word rendered "platform" in the maṇḍala instructions is obscure. The description of the blue vidyā-mantra holder's image, especially "legs spread apart," is uncertain. "Channels of the fields" renders "eyes of the fields," taken here as the openings of irrigation channels. In "May those of compassionate nature come," the verb is read as "come," treating the spelling as a copyist's slip. In the closing instructions, "the middle one" renders bar par, which could also mean "in the meantime." The verse line "Through those who send rain upon this land for its good" is syntactically uncertain.
• The verse begins mid-stanza, continuing from the previous piece. Its first line could be read in two ways: as an address to the Buddha, or as naming the source of the blessing ("through the King of Dharma..."). I have kept it as it stands, as a line of praise followed by the wish.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.